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The Song of Shim Ch'ong

The Tale of Shim Ch'ong¹

[1:1a]

aniri

송나라말년에 In the last years of the Sung dynasty there was a man in Tohwa Ward of Hwangju:² his family was the Shim and his name was Hak-kyu.³ As a family with many generations of official service they had enjoyed great renown but their fortunes turned and they became impoverished. Before he was twenty, Shim Hak-kyu went blind: a career of advancement to the capital with official rank⁴ was denied him and the glory of gold seals and purple ribbons⁵ became an empty dream. With a lot so harsh—not only blind but living in a corner of the countryside without relatives of any degree nearby—how could it be that no one gave him protection? But, still, being of yangban descent, with his unwavering principles and virtuous behavior, he earned the reputation of a gentleman and the praise of all.

His wife, Kwak-ssi,⁶ was good and wise. She had the virtue of T'ai Jen or T'ai Ssu, the beauty of Chuang Chiang, and the constancy of Mu Lan.⁷ There was nothing she did not know in the *Book of Rites*, *Family Rituals*,

*Home Rules, or Book of Songs.*⁸ She was on good terms with their neighbors in the village, kind but firm with slaves, and able to manage all the details of household affairs. While their poverty was like that of Yen Hui,⁹ she maintained the loyal integrity of Po I or Shu Ch'ï.¹⁰ In their one-room house with few family possessions, they lived from hand to mouth on a simple diet of vegetables and water. They had neither a plot in the fields nor a servant to live by the gate. The pitiful, good Kwak-ssi, disregarding her health, sold her labor for a living. [1:1b]

Doing needlework to earn an income: *chajin chung chung mori*
 Formal robes and overcoats, scholars' gowns, officials' robes,
 Military cloaks, soldiers' uniforms and battle dress,
 Coats for elder gentlemen, outer wear for men and women;
 Close quilting, hemstitching, horse-hair plaiting,
 Puckered quilting and piped hemming;
 Doing washing, starching, bleaching;
 Tops and bottoms for summer clothing,
 Plaited inner-hats and folded chin-straps,
 Waistcoat buttons, outer cuffs, and stockings,
 Anklets, purses, pouches, cuff-ties,
 Sashes, medicine pouches, and mufflers,
 Hoods, peaked and fur-lined caps, baby blankets,
 All sorts of bedding, pillowcases
 Embroidered with pairs of mandarin ducks,
 Black silk crowns and belts, embroidered crests of office.

Weaving silks and damasks, brocades and gauzes:
Kongdan, suju, and saengch'o;
T'onggyŏn, t'aju, and kapsa—
 Every weave of cloth in cotton, hemp, and ramie.

Making food for weddings, funerals, and other feasts:
Shinsŏlo, cookies, cakes, and pastries, [1:2a]
 Decorating with paper lotuses and phoenixes,
 Stacks of fruit and cake dyed in red, green, orange, and brown.¹¹

Three hundred sixty days a year
 Each day without a moment's rest;

She wears her fingers to the bone,
And sells her labor to get some savings.

She saves each *p'un* to make a *ton*,
And saves each *ton* to make a *yang*.¹²
At daily, short, and long-term interest
She lends it out to honest neighbors
Who all comply without a fault.

In observing memorials in spring and fall
And honoring her sightless husband,
And with clothing for the seasons and dishes for his table
And special foods to suit his taste,
And in harmonizing faithfully to his humors—
From beginning to end she is ever constant.

Neighbors in the upper and the lower villages all praised Kwak-ssi for her gentleness. aniri

One day, Blindman Shim said, "Pay me heed, good wife!"
"Yes?"

"Since men of yore, who has been born into this world and not had a mate? But, by some blessed affinity in a former life, we became man and wife in this world. With a blind husband like me, you never rest for even a moment; but, burdened day and night, you care for me to the utmost as you would a baby—preparing food and clothing at their proper times, anxious lest I'm hungry or lest I'm cold. I ought to be comfortable but, rather, all the hardship you endure as my wife makes my heart unquiet. From this day forward, be done striving thus for me and let us just live life as it comes. [1:2b]

"Nevertheless, since we have reached the age of forty without even one child at our knees, it is likely that the worship of our ancestors will end with us. Even when I'm dead and gone to the netherworld, what face will I have to present to our ancestors? And, considering our own lot, who will there be to bury and mourn us, observe the first two anniversaries, and then offer up even a bowl of rice and some water on that day in the years that follow? If your devotions to the gods of the great mountains and famous temples could bring us the fortune of a child, be it a boy or a girl—even a blind one—my life's sorrow would be dispelled. Please pray with all sincerity."

Kwak-ssi answered, saying, "It is said in an ancient text that the worst of three thousand unfilial acts is the failure to produce an heir.¹³ That we are without a son is all my fault. Though, rightfully, I should have been driven away, it is through your generosity that I have been kept on this long. My wish to bear a child is as fervent in day as night and, with every effort made,¹⁴ could I not do so? However, with our poor lot and my ignorance of your rightful heart, I could not speak right out. But since you have spoken first, I shall pray with all sincere devotion." [1:3a]

She sells her labors,
Offers up her every treasure,
And does every kind of good work:

chung mori

At great mountains, famous temples, and holy shrines,
Ancient altars, wayside temples, and village shrines;
For the many buddhas, bodhisattvas, and the Maitreya Buddha,
Ursa Major,¹⁵ Five Hundred Arhat, and the Sovereign Sakra,
The guardian spirit of the Flower Sutra and the spirit of the road.

She donates clothing to monks, oil for temple lanterns,
Paper for temple windows, and every sort of gift.
On days when she stays at home,
She offers devoted rites to the
Spirits of the kitchen, house, and earth.
How could a tower of such effort collapse
Or a tree of such pains be broken?

On the eighth day of the fourth month of the year *kapcha*¹⁶
She has a certain dream:
As an auspicious air coils up within the void
And the Five Colors shine brilliantly all around,
A fairy mounted on a crane
Descends from the skies.

She is wearing many-colored clothing
And, on her head, a flowered crown;
From her belt hang moon-shaped jade pendants
That chime against each other,
And in her hand she holds a sprig of laurel.

[1:3b]

She bows to Kwak-ssi, fingers pressed together,
And then approaches and sits down at her side:
It is as if the pure essence of the moon
Has entered into her embrace,
As if the Goddess of Mercy herself
Has risen again from the sea.
Her mind and body are swept by an ecstasy
She finds difficult to quiet.

Then the fairy speaks:

"I was the daughter of the Queen Mother of the West.
I was on my way to present the Sacred Peach¹⁷
When I met the concubine Yü-chen¹⁸
And the two of us fell to chatting.
With my lateness I had committed
A sin against the Jade Emperor¹⁹
And he had me banished to the human realm.

"I had no idea where to turn until
The Old Gentleman of Mount T'ai-hang,²⁰ the Earth Spirit,
The many buddhas and bodhisattvas, and Sakyamuni
Directed me toward your house.
Hence have I come and pray you take pity."

With this, the fairy enters her bosom
And Kwak-ssi wakes with a start
To find it all a passing dream.²¹

Forthwith she woke Blindman Shim to talk about the story of her dream: *aniri*
they had both had the same dream. By reason of something they did that
night, there were signs of pregnancy starting that month. Kwak-ssi, with
goodness in her heart,

Takes care not to sit in a seat improperly arranged, *chajin mori*
Nor eat food improperly cut,
Nor listen to unclean talk, [1:4a]
Nor look at ugly things,

Nor stand on one leg or lie on her side.²²
 When the tenth month is reached,
 One day the signs of childbirth are clear.

"Oh, my stomach! Oh, my back!"

Though Blindman Shim is, in one way, happy,
 He is also, in another, alarmed.
 He carefully spreads a handful of straw,
 Sets out a low table, and on it
 Offers a bowl of pure water.²³
 Then he kneels reverently before it.

"I pray. Lo, I pray."²⁴
 I pray before the Three Givers of Life.²⁵
 Kwak-ssi, with child at her late age:
 Please let her deliver as easily as
 A cucumber seed slips through an old skirt."²⁶

Suddenly, fragrance fills the room and
 He is encircled by vapors in the Five Colors.
 In this bewildering midst the birth occurs.
 Indeed, it is a daughter!

See now what Blindman Shim did!²⁷ He separated the baby from its sack and laid it down, his heart full of gladness. aniri

Just then Kwak-ssi recovered herself and asked, "Pay me heed, blind husband. Which is it, a boy or a girl?"

Blindman Shim laughed heartily and felt between the baby's legs. His hand slipped through without a pause like a ferry on its crossing.

"It seems as if the old clam has produced a fresh one!"²⁸ [1:4b]

Kwak-ssi, saddened, spoke, "After my prayers and deeds this child I bear in late years is but a daughter, you say?"

Blindman Shim responded, "Good wife! Cease that talk! Most important is that you have had a smooth delivery. With a child so well born, even though a daughter, would you trade her for just any son? Let us raise this girl with care, teaching her proper etiquette from the start, and all of needle-work and weaving. Then let us choose a fit husband for our gentle and

virtuous daughter. If they are happy, hearten each other, and produce throngs of progeny, cannot their sons remember us in their rites?"²⁹

He quickly prepared the first soup and rice³⁰ and, offering it on the altar to the Three Givers of Life, adjusted his clothing and headgear and prayed with his two hands raised, saying,

다 "I pray. Lo, I pray.
이 I raise my prayer before the Thirty-three Heavens,
가 The Western Paradise, and Indra.
다 I pray that the Three Givers of Life become as one
 And bend down to look upon me.

chajin mori

"The child we are given in our fourth decade
 Was a drop of dew in its first and second months;
 In the third month its blood took form;
 In the fourth month it took on human shape;
 In the fifth month the five organs were formed;
 In the sixth month the six feelings appeared;
 In the seventh month the frame took shape
 And the forty-eight thousand hairs grew;
 In the eighth month she had received her full burden;
 The Diamond Gate gently opened
 And she had an easy birth.³¹
 Was this not due to the Three Givers of Life?

[1:5a]

"Although not a son but a daughter,
 Pray give her the long life of Tung-fang Shuo,
 The virtuous behavior of T'ai Jen,
 The filial piety of the Emperor Shun and Tseng Ts'an,
 The faith of Ch'i Liang's wife,
 The talents of Pan Ch'ao,
 And for fortune, the wealth of Shih Ch'ung.³²
 May she have the blessing of an unbroken lineage.
 I pray you let her grow apace
 Like a cucumber or wild reed
 And mature by the day and month,
 Avoiding the many ills of childhood."

After serving up a bowl of hot soup and rice and feeding the baby's mother, he sang by himself as he fondled the child. aniri

"Rare as gold and fair as jade!
Oh, ho, my perky daughter!
Has Sukhyang of the P'yojin River
Been reborn in you?³³
Has the Weaving Girl taken your form
And come down to earth?³⁴

chung chung mori

"Had I fields to the north and south,
Could they give me greater joy?
Had I pearl and coral for my use,
Could I be more pleased?
Where have you been
That now you come to be mine?"

And in this way he enjoyed himself. But then, unexpectedly, Kwak-ssi developed secondary complications. Before the first seven days³⁵ had passed after birth, the wise and gentle Kwak-ssi was exposed to a draft and fell ill. aniri [1:5b]

"Oh, my stomach! Oh, my head! Oh, my chest! Oh, my legs!"

Her whole body was racked with unremitting pain. Blindman Shim, dumbstruck, felt all over where she hurt.

"Pull yourself together and speak to me! Is it indigestion? Have the Three Gods found fault with us?"

As her condition grew more and more serious, Blindman Shim became frightened. He brought over Mr. Song, the *saengwŏn*,³⁶ from the next village, who checked Kwak-ssi's vital signs and prescribed medicines. They tried asparagus root, lilyturf root, lizard-tail plant, orange peels, cassia bark, fu-ling mushrooms, beefsteak plant leaves, willow root, thoroughwax leaves, cinnamon, apricot pits, and peach stones. Just as the Emperor Shen Nung³⁷ had tasted the hundred herbs, so they, too, gave her medication and doctoring. But there is no medicine for a fatal illness.

Her condition became more and more critical until there was no prospect but death. Kwak-ssi, too, knew she could not survive.

She takes her husband's hand.
"Ah! Blindman!"
She gives a long sigh.

chinyang cho

"The two of us met each other
 And pledged to grow old together.
 But in our life of poverty
 Any carelessness of mine
 Could easily have caused distress
 To a master who cannot see;
 So I accepted all your wishes
 And tried to honor them.

[1:6a]

"Heedless of wind or cold or heat or damp,
 Selling my labors in villages north and south,
 I got us rice and other foods.
 I ate cold rice myself
 And offered warm to you—
 Caring respectfully that you
 Not go hungry nor be cold.

"Be it simply Heaven's will
 Or the cleaving of our destinies,
 There is nothing we can do.
 How can I close my eyes and go?
 Who will mend your clothing now?
 And who will press good food on you?

"Once I have died,
 My dim-eyed husband will be alone
 Without kin in any direction
 And with no one to rely upon.

"Carrying a gourd in one hand
 Grasping a cane in the other,
 Going out at mealtimes
 Only to fall into some ditch
 Or stumble over some rock
 And there bemoan his lot—
 As if seen with my very eyes.

“Going 'round from gate to gate,
 With his sad cry for food—
 Heard as if jangling in my ears.
 Though dead and but a shade,
 How could I bear to see and hear?

“Does this mean I am to die
 Without once nursing at my breast
 Or really knowing the face of this child
 I bear at forty after offering prayers
 At famous mountains and great temples?

[1:6b]

“And this young one,
 For some sin in a former life
 Born into this world only to be motherless,
 At whose breast will she nurse and grow?
 While you cannot cope alone,
 How can you manage her as well?
 What will you do with such a lot?

“How can I, overcome by tears,
 Set out for the distant Yellow Springs?³⁸
 The way is dark—how can I go?

“I have entrusted ten *yang* of cash
 To the family of Master Yi across the way.
 Will you get that ten *yang*
 And use it to defray the mourning costs?
 And in the chest I had set aside
 Some rice for my recovery.
 But now I am to die without it—
 So imminent draws my time.
 Please keep it for provisions
 After the mourning days are over.

“When I couldn't embroider all the crest
 On a set of robes of Inspector Chin,
 I wrapped them in a scarf

And put them in the bottom chest.
 When he comes to fetch them,
 After I die and the mourning is done,
 Please don't fret but give them to him.

"Kwidök's mother in the next village
 Has been a friend to me and used to visit;
 If you took the baby in your arms
 And asked her to nurse it,
 She surely would not refuse you.

[1.7a]

"If this child, with Heaven's grace,
 Doesn't die but lives to grow
 And walks on her own two feet,
 Then have her guide you as you ask the way
 And, seeking out my grave,
 There, teach her, saying,
 'This is the grave of your mother, who is dead.'
 If you brought this mother and daughter together,
 Though a spirit, I would be freed of anguish.

"There is no way to deny the will of Heaven.
 With you, blind husband,
 I leave the young one
 And make this last parting as I go.

"Do not let your precious health
 Suffer in grieving for me,
 But take good care of yourself in every way.
 We shall meet again to live out together
 The unfinished destiny of this life.

"Oh, Oh! I had forgotten!
 As a name for the child,
 Give her that of 'Shim Ch'öng.'
 The jade ring I used to wear
 Is kept in the small box;
 When Shim Ch'öng has grown
 Please give it to her as if to me.

chung mori

"I also made her a pretty red wool purse
 With knotted red silk drawstrings
 To which I tied the royal coins
 Engraved, *Perfect Peace and Comfort,*
Longevity, Happiness, Health, and Peace.
 Please give this to her wear as well."

[1:7b]

She suddenly dropped his hand, which she had been holding, and lay aniri
 back, sighing deeply. She then drew the baby to her and clucked her tongue
 as she rubbed its face against her own.

"The world is heartless and the gods are cruel.
 Were you only born a little earlier
 Or were I to live a little longer!
 But I die as soon as you are born.
 And now it is for you to know
 Unending and profound sorrow.

chung mori

"A dying mother and a living child:
 For what sin are we separated by life and death?
 At whose breast will you nurse and grow?
 In whose arms will you sleep?
 Oh, my child!
 Nurse at my breast this last time
 And grow, grow quickly!"

Tears in two streams wet her face.
 The wind, heaving sighs,
 Murmurs mournfully;
 The rain, forming tears,
 Falls plaintively;
 The sky hangs low,
 Thick with heavy clouds.

Birds crying in the woods
 Pause lonely to vent their passion;
 Water turning in the streams,
 Makes a piteous sound and

Sobs as it flows along.
With this, how can people not be sad?

[1:8a]

She hiccoughs two or three times.
And her breathing suddenly stops.

Blindman Shim knew at last that she was dead.

aniri

“Oh, no! Oh, no! Wife!
Have you really died?
What is this?”

chajin chung chung mori

He beats his breast, bangs his head,
Gets up and and down, prostrates himself,
Falls on his back, and stamps the floor
As he suffers in his agony.

“Oh, wife, pay me heed!
Were you to live and I to die,
Then you would raise the child;
But now I live and you are dead—
How will this child be raised?

“Oh, no! Oh, no!
Were we to live out our hard life
What would we eat to live?
Were we to choose to die together,
What would the youngster do?

“Oh, how shall I clothe and care for her
Against the cold winds of winter?
After moon-down in my gloomy, empty room
When she begs a breast to nurse,
At whose breast will she nurse and live?

“Oh, I beg you! Don't die, I beg of you!
It has been my lifelong hope that
We would die and lie together.
Where is this netherworld

For which you abandon me in death,
Leaving the child behind?

“If you leave us now, when will you return?
Will you follow the spring and
Come home again in its good company?³⁹
Will you come back with the moon
That has shone who knows how long in blue heaven?⁴⁰
Flowers fall then bloom again,
The sun sets to rise again;
But has my wife gone whence she cannot return?

[1:8b]

“Has she followed the Queen Mother of the West
To her Feast of the Sacred Peaches at Yao Lake?
Or has she joined Heng-o of the Lunar Palace
And gone aloft to grind medicines?⁴¹
Has she gone to Huang Ling Shrine
To share her thoughts with Nü Ying and O Huang?⁴²
Has she gone in search of Lady Sa
Who cried to heaven from Hoesa Pavilion?⁴³
Of whom am I to go in search?
Oh, no! The pain of it!”

As Blindman Shim lamented like this, the people of Tohwa Ward—
men and women, old and young alike—gathered and shed tears as they
spoke.

aniri

“Alas, wise and gentle Kwak-ssi is dead! How sad. We are more than
one hundred families; let us each give a share and see to her funeral!”

The consensus was expressed as if from one mouth. They selected a
spot for her on a sunny slope. They carefully dressed and blanketed the
body and laid it in a double coffin.⁴⁴ Then on the third day,⁴⁵ as the cortege
set forth, they sang a dirge.

“Wǒnǒ wǒnǒ!⁴⁶
Wǒnǒlli nǒmch’a wǒnǒ!

chung mori

[1:9a]

“They say the Pei-mang Hills are far,⁴⁷
But yonder hills are they!

Wönŏ wönŏ!

Wönŏlli nŏmch'a wönŏ!

"They say the Yellow Springs are far,
But here they are, outside the door!
Wönŏ wönŏ!

"How sad it is, the Lady Kwak-ssi!
Her conduct was so gentle,
Her talent was so rare!
She was neither young nor old,
But has forever left this world!
Wönŏ wönŏ!
Wönŏri nŏmch'a wönŏ!
Öhwa nŏwa wönŏ!"

Now see what Blindman Shim does
As they wend their way across.
The little baby, wrapped in swaddling,
He leaves in care of Kwidök's mother;
And, wildly grabbing his cane,
Cuts across the paddies and fields to catch up.
He hangs onto the back of the bier
But cannot cry loudly for his hoarseness.

"Heed me, wife! Let me die!
It is you who must live
And raise our little baby!
Most cruel of wives in all the world!
Left to live with you dead,
How can I in my blindness raise
This baby not yet seven days old?
Alas, alas!"

With Blindman Shim sadly crying, they arrived at the grave. After Kwak-
ssi was laid to rest and the earth was mounded up over her grave, the blind
man joined the ceremony, composing and reciting a eulogy with a heavy aniri
heart. [1:9b]

“Ah, sad lady! Ah, sad, lady!
 I had met this graceful gentlewoman;
 Her manner lacked nothing of the ancients!
 We had pledged ourselves one hundred years,
 But suddenly you die and your soul departs.
 You have left behind this child forever—
 How am I to raise it up?
 Oh, Heaven of no return!
 Will you ever come back to me?

chanted

“In your home of pine and catalpa,⁴⁸
 You are lain as if asleep.
 The face and voice I think of now
 Are remote for me—so difficult to see or hear.
 Tears flow, flow and wet my collar
 And the soaking tears become blood.
 My heart is anxious and I am estranged;
 There is no way for me to live.

“The person whom I cherish lies therein.
 Though I yearn, what use is it?
 Now that I have buried you,⁴⁹
 To whom can I turn?
 As the moon falls behind the aspens,
 The mountains grow desolate and the night profound.
 Whispers of sorrow fill my ears,
 But what appeal have I?

“Our worlds are set apart on different roads.
 Who will comfort her?
 Were we to ever met again,
 The sorrows of this life would fade.
 May you be sated, ere you depart,
 With the wine, fruit, dried meats,
 And salted fish of our simple offering.”

[1:10a]

He wildly recited the eulogy and then, his eyes crossing, cried out,
 “Alas! Alas, what is all this?
 Go! Go!

aniri
chinyang cho

What use is there in lamenting
 A wife who abandons me?
 There are no inns
 On the road to the Yellow Springs.
 At whose houses will you sleep as you go?
 Tell me where you are going!"

Blindman Shim wailed without restraint until he was calmed by the *aniri* funeral guests and taken home.

**집이
라
들
어
가
너** Blindman Shim enters his house
 To find the kitchen desolate
 And the rooms deserted.
 He hugs the little baby to him
 And lies alone in the utterly empty room,
 As lonely as a crab dropped by a jackdaw
 Deep within the T'aebaek Mountains.⁵⁰
 How can he be at peace?

chung mori

He stands up suddenly,
 Feeling the blankets
 And groping for the pillows.
 The bedding which always covered them
 Is there as ever
 But with whom will he be covered
 And sleep, alone in this empty room?

He pounds on the clothes chest
 And gropes wildly at the sewing box.
 He throws her comb box
 Spinning into the air
 And runs his hands over
 The small dining table
 Where he took his meals.

[1:10b]

Heading for the kitchen,
 He calls out uselessly
 And goes next door to ask in vain,